



Beware: An unofficial domain page impersonating the site, Book My Show, to dupe users.

on the backend, ready to be sold as leads to other scammers again, hence making the victim vulnerable to further waves of fraud.

Streaming into trouble

Not all con jobs, however, seek an immediate payday. Some are elaborately crafted to infect systems with malware that can operate silently in the background, draining crypto wallets, stealing passwords, backdoor applications, and installing remote-access implants. And that is where the sites seemingly offering free livestreams come into the picture.

First, these links are optimised for trending search keywords like 'ipl 2026 free live stream', 'watch ipl online free' and 'CSK vs RCB live streaming'. Sourajeet explains what happens next: "These threat actors will then go on Reddit or on different Facebook posts and talk about these fake IPL streaming sites. And let's say, they somehow get other people to also start talking about it. Now when you do a simple Google search for free IPL streaming sites, it will

come with an AI summary mode, right? The AI pop-up will start suggesting these sites because it will have picked up these community comments without actually verifying whether they are malicious."

If one eventually makes the mistake of landing on one of these websites and clicking one of the play buttons, hidden code in the advertisements redirects the user through multiple websites. These detours are designed to earn money from advertising and, in some cases, may lead to potentially harmful websites.

Additionally, a script on the site's source code helps identify operating systems, browsers, and devices. A specific macOS malware called 'SHub Stealer', which could potentially steal data, obtain credentials, trigger a browser data theft, read messages and infiltrate e-wallets, was also tracked.

The betting maze

The risks do not end with dummy tickets and malware-laden streaming portals. Waiting further down the rabbit hole is a sprawling network of illegal betting platforms.

Betting on sports has long been restricted in India under the Public Gambling Act, 1867, and state

gambling laws. Earlier, fantasy sports platforms such as Dream11 were allowed to operate after Courts classified them as 'games of skill'. However, the Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act, 2025, introduced a nationwide ban on online real-money gaming, effectively ending paid fantasy sports contests and other cash-based online gaming formats.

But some of these shady operations continue to operate in plain sight. A single admin panel revealed it was being used to manage 25 such websites. Also, over the past 12 months, more than 9,300 fund withdrawal requests were rejected on these sites, amounting to an estimated ₹4.65 crore in potential user losses.

Former IPS officer Neeraj Kumar, who has served as the Delhi Police Commissioner and also the Chief Advisor and head of the Board of Control for Cricket in India's (BCCI) Anti-Corruption and Security Unit (ACSU) from 2015 to 2018, says once the authorities discover how extensive the network is they will certainly take steps to curb its growth.

"When people get defrauded of all their savings by sharing things like OTP numbers or opening a